

**THE QUANDARY OF COMMERCIAL SEX WORKERS: AN EXCURSION INTO
EMENIKE AZUNWO'S *OROMA HOTEL***

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Abstract

This study examines the social, economic, and psychological conditions that shape the experiences of commercial sex workers in contemporary Nigerian society with Emenike Azunwo's Oroma Hotel as a primary text. Situating prostitution within global and local purview, the paper explores how poverty, unemployment, gender inequality, weak social welfare systems, and moral stigmatization collaborate to push young women into sex work as a means of survival. Drawing on the Commodification Theory, the study interprets sex work as a product of structural inequality in which the human body and intimacy are transformed into marketable commodities under conditions of economic desperation. Through a close reading of the characters of Patience and Clara-Ann, the paper brings to limelight vulnerability, exploitation, stigma, criminalization, and public shame as close associates of sex workers in Nigeria. The study recommends a shift in public discourse and policy from moral condemnation to social responsibility and human dignity. There is a need for stronger social welfare systems, accessible educational funding, youth employment programmes, and responsive economic policies that reduce the conditions causing young people into survival-based economies. The paper portrays drama as a powerful tool for interrogating social injustice within the discourse on sex work in Nigeria.

Keywords: Sex work, prostitution, survival, socioeconomic inequality.

Introduction

Prostitution is clearly a global idea which clarifies the sale of sexual services, typically for money or other forms of compensation, between a sex worker and a client (Weitzer, 2009). In a related interest, taking a psychological perspective, Farley (2004) defines prostitution as the provision of sex in exchange for payment, which can take many forms, including street prostitution, escort services, and brothels. Drawing from the definitions, it is safe to say that those who provide service(s) in this context are categorically commercial sex workers. In retrospect, commercial sex work is one of the most deliberated yet misconstrued forms of livelihood around the world. As a matter of fact, it is a big global industry that exists in a complicated space thus the clash of legality, morality, and public health.

Sizing the foregoing, while most countries of the world see it as crime, some notable countries like New Zealand and Germany grant sex works rights and protections as they legalize and/or decriminalize it (Platt et al., 2018). Given this instance, as already suggested, in many places particularly in Africa and Asia, commercial sex workers are highly stigmatized, in fact, prostitution is criminalized. This very condition leaves sex workers vulnerable to all sort of

abuse(s), poor healthcare, and social rejection. In Nigeria, the situation is no different. However, while prostitution is illegal under both secular and religious (Sharia) laws, enforcement is fairly irregular thus not the same everywhere. The Penal Code (used in the North) and the Criminal Code (used in the South) criminalize things like running brothels, pimping, and lobbying clients. Despite this fact, in major cities like Lagos, Port Harcourt, and Abuja, prostitution continues to thrive. Be that as it may, according to Atere and Alabi (2014), poverty, joblessness, and rural-to-urban migration are major reasons why many women enter the trade of prostitution. It however suffices to state firmly that sex workers in Nigeria often face daily harassment from the police, sexual abuse, and unfair treatment from the general public as they practice their trade (Amnesty International, 2019).

From a global outlook, prostitution is agreeably a problem. Relatively, given its local context, commercial sex work is as a matter of fact a social scourge. Given this outlook, whereas the issue has gained sociologically, psychological and medical attention, this paper is a careful attempt to grant the phenomenon a dramatic platform. Thus, with the play, *Oroma Hotel*, Emenike Azunwo explores the emotional, social, and financial struggles faced by sex workers in Nigeria. The play makes to challenge the common image of sex workers as immoral and instead portrays them as people who are also trapped by poverty, unhealthy environment, and a system that breeds frustration.

Ultimately, this paper situates Azunwo's *Oroma Hotel* as a heuristic material in exploring drama as a critical tool for reflecting and criticizing the problems associated with commercial sex work.

Prostitution: Conceptual Clarification

A widely recognized concept and/or phenomenon, individual scholars and organizations have defined prostitution in different ways across disciplines. However, on an ecumenical or say, simplest level, the idea of prostitution can be viewed as the exchange of sexual services for money or material gain. It is germane to state however that many scholars today prefer to qualify the idea as “sex work” because it borders around the activity as some sought of work or labour and is branded with issues of rights, health, and safety rather than that of morality or criminality (Global Network of Sex Work Projects, 2020). The understanding of the term as “sex work” is considerably a necessary shift because while “prostitution” colours moral and legal framework, the latter highlights agency and policy (right, health and safety).

Be that as it may, whereas, one can safely argue that prostitution is about survival for many individuals, the United Nations (UN) describes prostitution as having sexual relations in return for payment, often because the person has no other way to earn a living (UNODC, 2021). This standard definition defends the inkling that many commercial sex workers do it primarily for their survival. A good number of empirical studies capture the miscellany of sex work across Nigeria. According to Ikpeazu (2014), the practice can be brothel-based, venue-based (bars, clubs), street-based, and increasingly online. The motivations range from economic survival to lofty dreams, entrepreneurship etc. It is imperative to note however that the Nigeria law does not clearly define prostitution rather, the Nigerian Criminal Code (Section 225A) concentrate her attention on criminalizing related acts. Examples are: asking for sex in public (solicitation), running brothels, or making money from someone else's sex work. Given this instance, it

suffices to state that prostitution is seen as both morally and legally wrong in the eyes of the Nigerian law. According to Atere and Alabi (2014), prostitution in Nigeria is often about offering one's body for sex in exchange for money or other things. This practice is especially common in big cities like Port Harcourt, Lagos, Abuja, Warri etc., and is usually not done for fun or as a form of recreation. Rather, things like poverty, lack of jobs, and other related social problems have been suggestive of why many women delve into it, sometimes even against their will.

One can argue that the motivation, practice and outlook of prostitution is environmentally and culturally conditioned, thus, the explanation for different theoretical perspective on the phenomenon. Platt et al. (2018) holds that functionalist theorists treat prostitution as a social phenomenon that plays a role in social systems either for better or the reverse. Relatively, early sociologists argued that prostitution can serve latent functions. For example, prostitution provide a channel that prevents family disruption. However, while this lens is critical for explaining why prostitution may have persisted, it downplays its risks such as violence, coercion etc.

In another view, many feminists' sanction prostitution as inherently exploitative. For them, it is a form of patriarchal violence that commodifies women's bodies. Women involved in sex work are therefore encouraged to look at exit strategies. However, still within the feminist framework, other feminists and sex worker campaigners argue that consensual adult sex work can be legitimate labour. They are keen on the decriminalization of sex work, labour protections, and access to health and justice. This stance is increasingly represented in international guidance framework (Terminology and Statement Guide, 2023). In Nigeria both aspects appear in public debates: some NGOs see prostitution as a social problem that require rehabilitation while sex-worker advocate push for recognition and rights.

Another perspective is a Marxist based social theory called, conflict theory. This perspective defines prostitution as an economic and structural situated problem. In this instance, sex work is largely seen as a survival tactic for women and youth that formal labour markets can hardly accommodate (Chukwuedozie et al., 2019). Local idealists have many times identify poverty, unemployment, rural-urban migration, and lack of social safety as leading factors that push people especially young women into commercial sex work. In a related interest, focused on meanings, labels, and social identity, the stigma theory is another worthwhile perspective. According to Ankomah et al. (2011), Erving Goffman's work on stigma helps explain how being labelled a "prostitute" damages social identity and leads to exclusion. In Nigeria, strong and comprehensive moral framework (religious and cultural) often tag sex workers as immoral or dangerous. This very situation in a way compounds sex workers' marginalization and make it harder for them to access certain services and/or justice.

Summarily, it suffices to make the mention that while the word "prostitution" is still widely used in law and academic books, many groups that support sex workers prefer the term "sex work." They believe this term shows more respect and recognizes that sex workers deserve dignity and rights like everyone else (NSWP, 2020). However, while prostitution prompts and/or relates to a number of social concerns, it is viewed as a crime in Nigeria.

Theoretical Basis

Looked to be germane in the context of this discussion, the Commodification Theory will serve this study.

Built with Marxist inkling, the Commodification Theory is a model that technically explains how and why the woman body becomes commodified. According to James (2008), commodification is the process of converting absolute, free, or gifted things like objects, services, ideas, nature, personal information, people or animals into commodities, or objects for sale. In simple terms, the idea qualifies the process by which something that was not originally meant for sale or trade becomes part of the marketplace. Interestingly, it turns human qualities, experiences, or relationships into goods that can be exchanged for money.

Carl Marx developed the concept of commodification in one of his most important works, *Capital: A Critique of Political Economy*. Marx used the term to describe how, under capitalism, almost everything including human labour, creativity, and even human relationships can be converted into a commodity that has market value and can be bought or sold (Marx, 1867). Given this instance, it is safe to say that capitalism is built with the core idea of exchange value.

Granted the foregoing, it suffices to say that in Nigeria, where economic inequality, unemployment and hunger are widespread, commodification theory becomes a near perfect theoretical model to understand prostitution as a survival strategy. Atere and Alabi (2014) argue that poverty and materialism drive many women to trade sex as a form of livelihood. The human body, in this sense, becomes a market asset shaped by social and economic pressure. In a related interest, Otu (2010) explains that in urban Nigeria, the female body becomes a site for oppression and a means of economic survival. This instance makes clearer the conviviality that exist between commodification and poverty. The foregoing point can be easily affiliated with the idea that due to rapid urban migration, unemployment especially among youth, and the struggle for material comfort have commercialized sex and made it part of Nigeria's informal economy.

In summary, the Commodification Theory is a model that simplifies the understand how capitalism turns human attributes such as sex, labour, and emotion into tradable goods. In the context of this discussion, this very model shows how socio-economic forces transform human intimacy into a commercial transaction. Thus, prostitution. In a society like Nigeria, where unemployment, poverty and inequality continue to persist, Commodification Theory becomes a perfect tool that displaces the complication of why commercial sex work continues to thrive despite the derogatory interpretation attached to the practice.

Emenike Azunwo's *Oroma Hotel* in Context

Synopsis

Oroma Hotel presents the emotional yet intense story of two young women, Patience and Clara-Ann, whose paths come in contact with a harsh social and economic environment. Faced with the challenge of funding their education in a society that provides little educational support, the two are gradually drawn into commercial sex work: first out of curiosity and later as a result of growing financial pressure. What begins as a perceived short-term solution to their economic difficulties soon exposes them to serious personal and social risks.

Patience appears outwardly confident and resourceful, adopting a bold persona that conceals her

inner vulnerability. Clara-Ann, in contrast, is more reserved and hesitant, struggling with the moral implications of their choices even as financial necessity pushes her forward. As they move through hotel rooms and build networks shaped by deception and false promises, they encounter individuals who exploit their vulnerability under the guise of assistance and/or companionship. Over time, their attempt to escape poverty leads them into deeper danger. They become entangled in all kinds of scheme, betrayals, and criminalized spaces. Soon, they become attracted to the law enforcement and subject for public condemnation. The private decisions they make in the hope of survival soon become public spectacles marked by shame, fear, and lasting consequences.

Oroma Hotel and Sex Work: A Contextual Discussion

Emenike Azunwo's *Oroma Hotel* is situated within a familiar yet disturbing social landscape in contemporary Nigeria. This landscape is marked by unemployment among youth, rising educational costs, gendered vulnerability, and socioeconomic inequalities. The play does not treat sex work merely as a sensational backdrop; rather, it uses the hotel space as a microcosm of a society in which poverty, power, and hypocrisy meet. Through the experiences of Patience and Clara-Ann, one can see and feel a human-centered exploration of sex work as a survival strategy shaped by government and institutional fiasco rather than simple moral failure.

In many Nigerian urban centers, the cost of education continues to rise against the backdrop of poverty, high unemployment and underemployment among young people. Access to scholarships, student loans, or institutional welfare remains limited. This reality leaves many students whom are fairly vulnerable to rely on informal economies to survive. Within this purview, the play's portrayal of young women (Patience and Clara-Ann) who turn to sex work to finance their education reflects a recognizable social reality.

Patience: (Applies her finish touches carefully as she concentrates on the mirror) I think it's necessary to have a rough hair, smeared mascara, and a dazed eye afterwards.

Clara-Ann: Even when it's not worth it?

Patience: (Smiles) For twenty-five thousand naira, it's worth it. If the man is weak, and can't go further and harder like the others, act like he's going further and harder like the others. If he has a tiny pole, act like it's the biggest you've ever seen. (Turns to Clara) That's the tricks...

Clara-Ann: But why? It doesn't make sense to pretend. (Stares at her for seconds and continue with the mirror) For twenty-five thousand naira, you're an academy award winning actress.

Patience: (Stares at her for seconds and continue with the mirror) For twenty-five thousand naira, you're an academy award winning actress.

Clara-Ann: Acting is not pretense (Azunwo, p.11).

The decision is clearly not framed as a natural inclination toward vice but as a response to material deprivation and social neglect.

Oroma Hotel therefore bring into line the sociological readings of sex work as a product of economic inequality. The characters' entry into sex work emerges from a context where legitimate opportunities are scarce and survival strategies are normalized in the informal sector. Given this instance Azunwo uses his work to draw attention to the structural forces like poverty,

unemployment, weak welfare systems etc. that shape individual choices. Sex work here can be viewed less as a personal moral failure and more as an unnatural response to limited options, opportunities and resources.

Another daring outlook is the hotel as a metaphor. It is critical to look at the hotel in the play per function as more than a physical setting. In this context, it is a symbolic space where private transactions mirror public contradictions. Ideally, hotels are traditionally associated with hospitality, anonymity, and temporary residence. However, in *Oroma Hotel*, these qualities become metaphors for the precarious and hidden nature of sex work. The secrecy of hotel rooms enables transactions to take place beyond public scrutiny.

Patience: (Shakes her head) Indeed... Do you think you have time? You don't have that my sweet girl. Babe, I'm running late and I have to get going now...

Clara-Ann: Alright... So, where's the place?

Patience: Kingston hotel. You know there?

Clara-Ann: No, but, if need be, I can find it (Azunwo, p.13).

This very purview explains why sex-work is often dressed with stigmatization and perfumed with criminality. At the same time, the hotel becomes a marketplace where ideally untradable ideas/things like bodies, intimacy, and trust are exchanged for money. This background exposes the commodification of human relationships under conditions of economic desperation.

Similarly, the play foregrounds the gendered dimensions of sex work. Patience and Clara-Ann's experiences reveal how young women's bodies become sites of negotiation, survival, and exploitation within patriarchal and economic contexts. Patience's outward confidence can be read as a coping mechanism. A performance of control in a space where power largely lies with strange clients and intermediaries.

Desmond: (Smiles at Patience) Hello!

Patience: Hi

Desmond: How are you?

Patience: (Looks and nods) I'm fine...

Desmond: So how much for the night?

Patience: When you talk like that, it makes me feel like a prostitute.

Desmond: (Chuckles) Are you not?

Patience: Is your mother a prostitute?

Desmond: Who... Forgive me please... No offense.

Patience: Me too.

Desmond: (Thinks) So, you don't prostitute?

Patience: No, not to your kind.

Desmond: (Surprise) My kind!

Patience: (Looks at him) You make money to fund your misogyny.

Desmond: That's either prejudice or stereotype from you.

Patience: No, it's the truth. (Nods)

Desmond: (Smiles) If you wanted a Cinderella treatment, you wouldn't be here.

Patience: Oh, okay, fairy godmother.

Desmond: (Impressed) I really want to hang out with you.

Patience: Won't that little wallet of yours bend under the pressure of patronizing me?
Desmond: It's a heavy wallet that needs to lose weight, but it doesn't seem to lose weight no matter how much it's worked.
Patience: Fifty thousand naira, and you'll have my attention. (Prides himself)
Desmond: What will one hundred thousand naira do?
Patience: (Sits up) It'll get you, my phone number. (Pause and admires him) I like your confidence; you carry yourself well...
Patience: I'm a gem.
Desmond: A germ?
Patience: You're not funny.
Desmond: (chuckles). My mother says the same thing.
Patience: Have you ever been tied?
Desmond: I get that for one hundred thousand naira?
Patience: No, for two hundred thousand.
Desmond: Wow. Deal.
Patience: Deal! Then we swim the sea of adventure...
Desmond: But it's not for me.
Patience: (Pause) what! (Looks at him) Then, who is it for?
Desmond: My boss. (Points). He's at that table.
Patience: (Looks at the direction Desmond points at and sees a fat ugly man that looks rich and sighs) Jesus! (Azunwo, p.20).

Through these characters and the scenarios associated with them, *Oroma Hotel* explores the relationship that exist between gender and poverty and how they affect vulnerability. The risks sex workers face is complex; deception, violence, entrapment, criminalization amongst others. These issues are fairly not random but structured by unequal power relations. Men appear in multiple guises: as clients who purchase access, as intermediaries who promise protection, and as authorities who enforce the law. This complicated appearance and multiplicity reflects the contradictory positions men occupy in the political economy of sex work. One of the strengths of Azunwo's portrayal is his refusal to reduce sex workers to stereotypes. Patience and Clara-Ann are shown as complex individuals negotiating fear, hope, guilt, and survival.

Clara-Ann: (Objects) Where are we going?
Madam Hawk: (Looks at her and smiles) Upstairs.
Clara-Ann: How much?
Women: (Surprise) See oh!
Madam Hawk: Name your price.
Clara-Ann: Ninety thousand naira. (The women laugh)
Madam Hawk: Four hundred thousand naira? That one na money?
Mama Franco: Madam Hawk herself.
Madam Hawk: (Cuts in) Clara-Ann, my love
Clara-Ann: Ma?
Madam Hawk: I'll give you a million if you let me enjoy you. And Mama

Franco will still give you the four hundred thousand naira, so you're leaving this place with 1.4 million naira.
 Clara-Ann: (In shock) Jesus! (They laugh)
 Madam Hawk: What do you say?
 Clara-Ann: Yes, please! (Nods excitedly as Mama Hawk leads Clara-Ann into the reception hall. Perry calls and goes after Clara-Ann but Mama Franco obscures him as the drummers kick in as light fades out) (Azunwo, p.65).

The play has brought up some moral questions: Can choices made under economic duress be judged by the same standards as choices made in conditions of security? Where does responsibility lie when social structures systematically fail young people? Whereas these questions grapple for answers, *Oroma Hotel* puts sex work within a continuum of constrained choices rather than as an isolated moral aberration. Apparently, this perspective corroborates contemporary human-rights-oriented tactics that is attentive of human dignity, safety, and social support over abuse and/or chastisement.

Taking a stroll from individualistic narratives, *Oroma Hotel* is in its right a sound critique of systemic failure. There is in fact a clear indication that educational institutions appear distant from students' socioeconomic realities; social welfare mechanisms are weak and/or absent; law enforcement operates punitively rather than protectively. The result is a social environment in which demeaning and dangerous informal economies become rational survival strategies.

In conclusion, it is safe to say that *Oroma Hotel* presents a deep and compassionate exploration of sex work in contemporary Nigerian society. Through the experiences of Patience and Clara-Ann and the symbolic space of the hotel, the play reveals how poverty, gendered power relations, stigma, and criminalization join forces to shape the realities of sex work. Be that as it may, rather than presenting prostitution as purely a moral issue, Azunwo frames it as a human predicament shaped by unnatural choices within a failing social setup.

Conclusion/Way-Forward

By and large, this study has shown that Azunwo's *Oroma Hotel* presents more than a dramatic portrayal of prostitution; it presents a compassionate and critical reflection on the social conditions that produce and sustain commercial sex work in Nigeria. Through the experiences of Patience and Clara-Ann, the play exposes how poverty, unemployment, rising educational costs, gendered vulnerability, and weak institutional support systems corner young women into making difficult and often dangerous choices. The play as well as the work in general challenges dominant moral narratives that label sex workers as bad. In reverse, it portrays them as individuals responding to harsh socio-economic realities.

With the application of Commodification Theory, the paper reinforces the foregoing idea. Specifically, it demonstrates how capitalism and material deprivation transform the human body and intimacy into economic resources within informal markets. This theoretical framing goes as far as moving the discussion beyond individual blame thus, situate a broader critique of structural inequality and systemic failure. The stigmatization and criminalization of sex workers, as depicted in the play, further deepen their vulnerability. In context, it is within frame

to say that this outlook limits their access to justice and social protection.

Granted the entirety of the foregoing, this study recommends a shift in public discourse and policy from moral condemnation to social responsibility and human dignity. There is a need for stronger social welfare systems, accessible educational funding, youth employment programmes, and responsive economic policies that reduce the conditions that pushes young people into survival-based economies. In addition, legal and institutional reforms should prioritize the protection of vulnerable populations from violence, exploitation, and abuse rather than relying solely on punitive measures.

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